In the first innings I was out bowled for five to a ball that jumped a little and ricocheted off my elbow onto the stumps. It was a rather disappointing dismissal after all the build-up. At Lahli, most matches are low-scoring and, sure enough, our reply to their first-innings total of 134 was only two runs more. It was a keenly contested match and in our second innings we were set 240 to win, which in a way was more like 280 because of the slow outfield.

I had a brief chat with my team-mates in the innings break and emphasized to them the need to be aggressive after the opposition had bowled close to fifty overs, which would be approximately around teatime. On a pitch offering assistance to the fast bowlers, that was the best time for batsmen to cash in and score quickly, because that was when the ball would be older and the opposition bowlers tired. Better to take a few chances then than wait for the morning, when the bowlers would start fresh and the new ball would also be due.

Dhawal Kulkarni, the fast-medium bowler, and I had a really good partnership towards the end of the day's play and I kept telling him that he needed to hang in there at any cost. There wasn't much batting left after him and a new batsman would find it difficult on the greenish pitch. Dhawal batted extremely well and showed great courage. He was hit on the helmet a couple of times but never got rattled or gave up. By the end of the day we needed 39 runs to win, with four wickets left.

It was a 9 a.m. start on the last day and it was important to make the right call with the roller. Having seen the wicket, I told Zaheer, our captain, that the grass was dry at the top but at the bottom it was still wet. It still needed some sun to dry out completely. If we took the heavy roller the wetness would spread to the top and the pitch would turn damp. I suggested that we should not use a roller but just leave the surface as it was, because all that was required was 39 runs, which wouldn't take more than an hour or so to get.

Again Dhawal batted well and showed great resilience and we managed to knock off the runs in an hour or so. His contribution of 16 was critical because on that surface we could easily have lost the last four wickets for ten runs. I was pleased to remain unbeaten on 79 in my final Ranji outing. It was a satisfying victory and a good way for Mumbai to start their Ranji Trophy campaign.

At the end of the game, the Haryana team gave me a guard of honour and my own team-mates chaired me off the ground on their shoulders.